



Security Watch

Multimedia Woes All Over Again

Problem

There is a new Trojan out there that works by infecting all multimedia files (that would be music and movies) stored on the user's machine. The Trojan spreads mainly through music file on P2P networks with the goal of letting hackers remotely access your system. When the infected music file is played Internet Explorer is launched and a page is loaded which prompts the user to download a codec which is actually a Trojan.

Once the Trojan is on your machine it embeds its malicious code into all ASF (Advanced Systems Format) based multimedia files. The ASF format is used by files such as MP3, WMA and WMV. The interesting thing about this Trojan is that it infects media files already on your hard disk and will convert all the MP2 and MP3 files stored on your PC to WMA. In order to maintain an air of authenticity, after the download is complete you will not be prompted again. The Trojan also has properties of a worm as users who download music from your system will also get infected.

Solution:

Don't download codecs from unknown sites. Update your anti-virus program by downloading the latest virus pattern file and scan your computers. Any decent anti-virus would detect and clean the malware. If you are currently running in safe mode, please restart your computer normally before performing the scan.

FIND ME NOW!

Free Laptop-Tracking System Hits The Streets

No matter what you do to protect yourself, passwords, encryption, biometrics, firewall, and an anti-virus, you still have one major worry and that's theft. The one thing worse than that, is mistakenly losing it, because that makes it *your* fault, and that's naturally worse than anything else.

Once you'd lost or had your laptop stolen, you relied entirely on the good faith of humanity or at the very least, a police force, to recover your device. Researchers at Washington University and California University have joined up to create Adeona that secures laptop data.

Researchers at the University of Washington and the University of California, San Diego, have launched Adeona, an open source service aimed at helping consumers and businesses track the location of lost or stolen laptops. Adeona is an independent system, which doesn't rely on any third party software or a central server. You install it and it works, nothing more to it.

It's designed to answer the needs of corporations and government entities that have seen an increase in personal data breaches because of missing laptops, as well as consumers who are putting more music, photos and memories on to their portable computers.

Initially, the research project was not about delivering a service for

people. They were originally looking at the privacy implications of some of the device-tracking systems now on the market. But as they delved further, they realised they were going to develop a client that people would be interested in using.

Interest stems from the fact that existing commercial laptop-tracking products involve someone besides the owner having access to personal data.

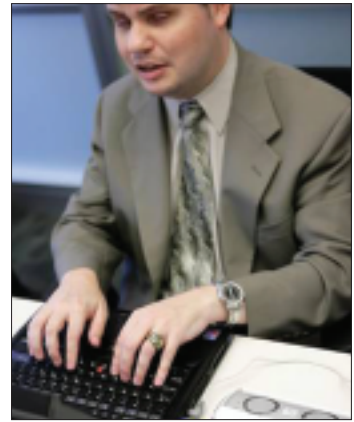
Users install Adeona onto their laptops, which then set up encrypted connections to the open source OpenDHT storage servers on the Web. If a user loses a laptop or is the victim of theft, another download and a password allows him to track his device via last-known Internet protocol (IP) addresses and Internet nodes that were used to connect to the missing machine. Users are the only ones to see the information about their laptops.

We do have questions about whether an open source based tracking system would itself be secure, since any developer would have access to the source code. The fact that it's open source makes the structure of security visible to the bad guys as well. Corporations don't open source security for that reason.

FOR THE VISUALLY IMPAIRED

Web Access For All

WebAnywhere, developed by a computer science graduate student at the



University of Washington is a Web-based screen reader for the Web. It requires no special software to be installed on the client machine. Therefore, it enables blind people to access the Web from any accessible computer with a sound card.

Blind people generally use screen-reader software while using computers. However, these products can cost more than \$1,000 (Rs 45,000), so they're not exactly common on public PCs at libraries or Internet cafes. Jeffrey Bigham, the developer of a new free Web-based program hopes his program would let blind people check a flight time on a public computer at the airport, plan a bus route at the library or type up a quick e-mail at an Internet cafe.

To use WebAnywhere, a blind person has to get online. This can be troublesome with computers not setup to be able to respond to voice commands. However, according to Bigham, Web-savvy blind people often know plenty of keyboard tricks and when to ask for help.

Once online, a blind Web surfer can have any Web page read out loud with the help of the WebAnywhere browser. All you need to have are speakers or headphones. The program